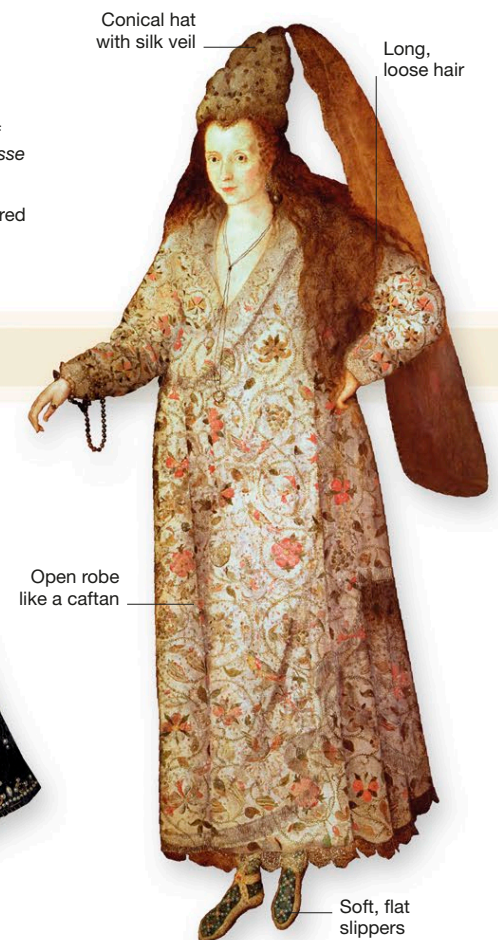




Iconographic suit English courtiers like Richard Sackville, 3rd Earl of Dorset, delighted in playing with symbols on their clothing to send messages about their family, virtues, and political allegiances. Celestial motifs denoting the heavens were popular, like those on Sackville's hose.



The natural world The lustrous petticoat and stomacher of Elizabeth I have been painted with exquisite, naturalistic pictures of plants and animals. Some are mythical, but most are real, indicating the queen's knowledge of the natural world, including strange sea creatures.



Masque costume This unknown lady of the 1590s is dressed as the Persian maiden from Boissard's 1581 costume book. Artists drew on illustrations of exotic costume as a design resource. Boissard's book inspired architect Inigo Jones's famous masque costumes.

BLACKWORK AND EMBROIDERY

As undergarments peeped out from clothing in the 15th century, Italian and Spanish needlework was used to embellish the visible edges. Blackwork is the English name for an embroidery technique using red or black silk thread in geometric, stylized patterns on linen garments for both sexes, such as shirts, smocks, coifs, and caps.

After the idea came to England local needlewomen built on the technique. By the Elizabethan and Jacobean periods, complex twining patterns of naturalistic plants and animals covered outer clothing in a tangle of multicolour designs accented with gold. The exuberance contrasted with the geometric formalism of garments.

